There is little doubt that this post-independence struggle — over how to bring unity and protection of the Bamar (or more widely the Buddhist) majority — has influenced subsequent democratic thought in the country.[7] The "disciplined democracy" advocated by the State Peace and Development Council — and more recently the Thein Sein government — attempts to maintain the supposedly stabilizing "guardian" role of the military within governance. And in contemporary narratives of democratization from within the opposition movement, and from leaders such as Aung San Suu Kyi, the fear of disunity also features strongly. Thus when considering recent reactions to communal violence in Myanmar, it is important to place these in the context of modern political thought in the country, and particularly the necessary emphasis on unity, and protection of the majority.

The rise of communal violence and Muslim–Buddhist tension is a pressing concern for the Bamar activists and opposition leaders involved in this study. Yet underlying some of the discussion of Muslim–Buddhist tensions is a *moral* — as opposed to *liberal* — narrative of Myanmar's democratization. The *liberal* narrative is premised on formal procedures and institutions — backed by commitment to universal human rights and protection of minorities — as the primary means of containing political conflicts and tensions in society. In contrast, and echoing U Nu's perspectives, the *moral* narrative of democratization portrays internal change as the primary means of containing political contest. It requires the progressive laying aside of one's own individual interests for the good of the whole (Interview 5, 2013 English). Thus on the one hand, among Western donor agencies the word "democracy" is often imbued with liberal values. And it should be noted that the conceptual relation between liberalism and democracy has its own inherent tensions. Yet on the other hand, among Burmese activists, "democracy" is commonly linked to personal *moral* values such as unity and benevolence (or *cetana)*.

For example, activist and writer U Wunna stressed that the primary need in the country's democratization is for leaders who are *tageh seit shi de lu* or "people with true motivation" (Interview 1, 2013 Burmese). Meanwhile, opposition political leader U Aung Naing (Interview 5, 2013 Burmese) pointed to the importance of *cetana* in the country's transition to democracy. In this sense, it is insufficient for a leader to have only knowledge or technical skills in governance. They must also demonstrate